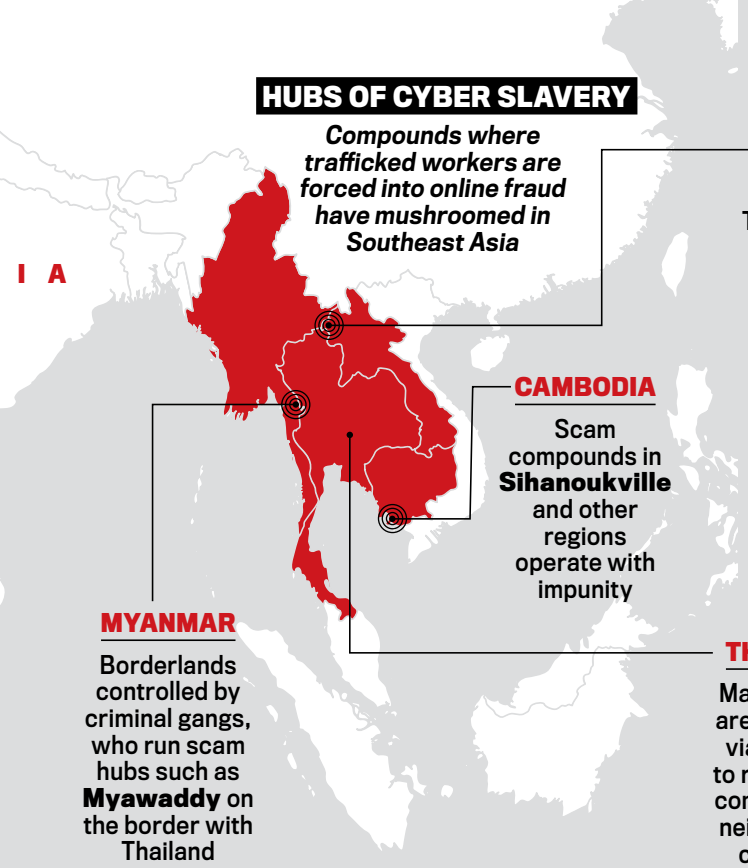
HUBS OF CYBER SLAVERY

Compounds where trafficked workers are forced into online fraud have mushroomed in Southeast Asia



LAOS

Golden Triangle SEZ in **Bokeo** province houses large-scale scam operations

CAMBODIA

Scam compounds in **Sihanoukville** and other regions operate with impunity

MYANMAR

Borderlands controlled by criminal gangs, who run scam hubs such as **Myawaddy** on the border with Thailand

THAILAND

Many victims are trafficked via Thailand to reach scam compounds in neighbouring countries

WHAT INDIA IS DOING TO SAVE ITS CITIZENS

Rescue Operations
Indian embassies have helped rescue over 2,300 trafficked citizens from scam compounds in last three years. But the government does not know how many are still trapped

Nationwide Crackdown
Since May 2024, the NIA has carried out over 40 raids across multiple states, arresting 11 key operatives and filing at least four chargesheets against individuals suspected of luring victims with fraudulent overseas job offers

Visa Screening
Stricter verification of job-related visa applications to high-risk countries

Public Awareness
Government campaigns to educate job seekers about such global frauds, warnings issued on social media platforms

Bait & Switch
Upon arrival, passports are confiscated and victims are moved to 'fraud factories', forced into cyber scams instead of real jobs

Threats & Violence
Those who resist are beaten, starved, kept in isolation or even sold to other scam operations

Ransom Demands
As a last resort, families are pressured to pay huge sums for the release of their loved ones



◀ **THE LUCKY FEW**
A group of trafficked Indians brought back from Cambodia at the Visakhapatnam airport in May 2024

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

THE HUMAN COST

Those who have made it back consider themselves lucky, yet they remain haunted by their ordeals. Take the case of Shubham Kumar, 28, from Hathua Bazar in Gopalganj, who was deceived by a trusted acquaintance—his friend's father. Promised a salary of Rs 1 lakh per month in Cambodia, Shubham paid Rs 1.5 lakh commission upfront. In November 2023, he took off from Kolkata, travelling to Ho Chi Minh City in Vietnam on a tourist visa. Upon arrival, his cash and passport were confiscated and he was handed over to a Chinese syndicate, known as the DG Group, based in Cambodia's Sihanoukville—a city now synonymous with cyber slavery.

Here, Shubham encountered individuals from multiple nationalities, all first trained in the "art of deception" and then coerced into conducting meticulously orchestrated online scams—often working in gruelling 12-16 hours shifts. "The mission was explicit: target Indian nationals and systematically swindle them," recalls Shubham. The criminal syndicates employed a vast array of schemes to fleece victims, from romance fraud and fictitious investment opportunities to fraudulent e-commerce ventures. Among these, investment scams proved to be the most effective. Initial investments yielded genuine returns,